might do things that were better than "Nightfall," The Foundation Trilogy, I, Robot, or The Caves of Steel, but surely not much better. These were already recognized as classics, and I had been writing for fifteen years and I had yet to make more than ten or eleven thousand dollars a year as a writer.

I didn't see how I could ever do better than that, especially since there was bound to come a time soon when a new and younger group of writers would take over and sweep myself and my contemporaries from the field—as we had done to the writers of the 1930s.

This volume of my autobiography, then, is the tale of my moving in, deeper and deeper, into the specialized world of biochemistry and science fiction, until I reached the dead-end wall that marked my limit. Taking into account my starting point at ground level, I had every right to count myself a success; but I was a very modest success indeed, and I was left ruefully unsatisfied.

Yet where could I find a way of moving out as I had moved in, but to a much higher level? What on earth could I do besides my biochemistry and my science fiction?

I had been writing straight science, of course, but some of it had been for the science-fiction magazines and was bound up entirely with my science fiction. Some of it had been for chemical journals and went nowhere. A good deal of it had gone into the textbook and had failed ignominiously.

That left my little book The Chemicals of Life, which was just being published. It actually represented my first move out, though I surely didn't recognize this at the time.

How, beginning with that book, I overleaped the blank wall I faced—not without trouble and controversy—and how I succeeded in reaching heights I was utterly unable to foresee in 1954, and how I reached the point, in fact, where Doubleday could actually make itself believe that the world might be interested in two fat volumes of autobiography by me, will be the tale of that second volume.

Catalog of Books Isaac Asimov

Note: The numbers preceding the titles of books refer to the order in which they were published.

Part I — Fiction